



SWEET REVENGE

Shakespeare learned to write by watching and acting in plays like Thomas Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy*. Kyd (1558–1594) invented a new type of play called a “revenge tragedy,” in which a murder is committed and then violently avenged. One of Shakespeare’s first plays was the bloodthirsty revenge tragedy, *Titus Andronicus*.

The playwrights

THE LONDON STAGE OF the early 1590s was dominated by the plays of a group of well-educated men nicknamed the “University Wits.” The group included Robert Greene, Thomas Nashe, and Christopher Marlowe. They wrote plays in unrhymed lines of 10 syllables called “blank verse,” like Marlowe’s “Is this the face that launched a thousand ships?” By 1592, Shakespeare was also an established playwright. Greene wrote an attack on him that year, calling him an “upstart crow.” He looked down on Shakespeare because he had not gone to a university. But Shakespeare was a success

partly because he was a mere player – he knew what worked on stage and what did not.

The sloping surface allows the quill pen to be held at the right angle to the paper



SITTING COMFORTABLY

Before becoming a playwright, Thomas Kyd worked as a scrivener, or copier of documents. Sitting at a desk like this, he would have spent his days writing letters for people who could not write, and making neat copies of legal documents and plays. Most playwrights did not have special writing desks. They wrote wherever they could, often on tables in rented rooms and taverns.



Oak leaf with gall

INKY INGREDIENTS

The black ink used by playwrights was made from a curious mixture of ingredients. The most important were swellings called galls found on oak trees. The galls were ground up and mixed with water or vinegar and a chemical called green vitriol, which was produced by pouring acid over rusty nails. The final ingredient was gum arabic, the dried sap of the acacia tree.

Rusty nails

17th-century inkwell and quills



*“Now, Faustus, let thine eyes with horror stare
Into that vast perpetual torture-house,
There are the furies tossing damned souls
On burning forks. Their bodies broil in lead.”*

CHRISTOPHER MARLOWE
Evil Angel in *Dr Faustus*